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Carol Bash

Carol Bash is a 1985 graduate of Hamilton College and has worked in broadcasting for PBS, HBO and the BBC. She founded Paradox Films in 1992 and at the time of this interview was completing work on her first independent film, the documentary "Mary Lou Williams/The Lady Who Swings the Band."

Carol was interviewed in Clinton, NY on April 2, 2012 by Monk Rowe, director of the Hamilton College Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe and we are here in the Jazz Archive at Hamilton College with our guest Carol Bash, Hamilton alum and documentary filmmaker. And I'm pleased to be able to show your film for one of the first times, even though it's not quite done, but it was a great experience for us.

CB: Thank you, thank you. It's great to be here. Thanks, Monk.

MR: It's nice that you're focusing on Mary Lou Williams, a person who doesn't show up in the history books as often as she should. Is that something that drove you to do this.

CB: Yeah, absolutely. When I first came to Mary Lou, basically it was through her music. And I was at my in-laws' house. My husband is also a Hamilton alum. But anyway, I was in their house and my father-in-law was playing Mary Lou Williams on the stereo, and I just was bowled over by her music. And I asked him who is this playing, and he said Mary Lou Williams, she's one of the greats. And I was like I'd never heard of her. And I knew jazz, I mean the names. But I had never heard of her. And when a book came out about her life, I'd say a year or so later, I read about this woman I was just so fascinated about her life and her life story, and kind of sad about the fact that I had really never heard of her, and just decided then that I was going to try to change that through telling her story through film.

MR: Yeah. It's serendipitous that that book came out, sort of like the planets aligned a little bit for you. I found it interesting, I have to admit too that I didn't know enough about her when your film came up and then I took out some music to listen to. And her solo piano playing had a touch of really raw basic blues, almost like to the point of, I almost felt like she was even an older soul playing stuff from the turn of the century almost. It's very interesting.

CB: Um hum. Well you know that's her philosophy. Her philosophy about jazz is that it came from the blues, it came from the suffering of black people. And she said without the blues there is no jazz. So it's all about the blues for Mary Lou, and yeah, it just resonates throughout no matter what style she's playing, because you know she plays so many

styles. But whatever it is, you know, she still has that blues kind of heavy duty rhythm and beat to her music, that makes it swing.

MR: And she swung.

CB: Yes she did.

MR: Was it always your intention to find a way to make a living a little bit off the beaten path?

CB: I think so, yeah. I was never one to sort of say oh I want to be that banker. I was never a business-oriented nine to fiver kind of person. I was always interested in writing or photography, something visual. So yeah, I guess you could say I was a creative kind of soul and knew that whatever I ended up doing would have to be somewhat creative.

MR: And for students nowadays, what's the best avenue if they want to be a film maker? I mean you got a masters in New York.

CB: Um hum. From the New School.

MR: And is that masters sort of broad-media based study?

CB: The media studies masters that I got really helped to get me more informed about cinema history. I also was very interested in production, meaning actually, how to hold the camera, how to edit, the hands-on nuts and bolts of production, that I didn't get from my previous experience working in news. You weren't allowed to touch the equipment in news, because it was union. So yeah, I basically realized that to get that kind of experience I needed to go back to school. But as far as getting into the business, there are so many different avenues. There is actually no one great way. It just is varied. Whether it's knowing somebody and just sort of falling into it and learning on the job, that's fine. You don't have to go to school to do what I do. You can get this experience learning on the job as well.

MR: Like how people used to learn to play jazz.

CB: Exactly.

MR: On the bandstand.

CB: Right. Because school is a great foundation for some people, for some people. But really, you're going to learn this job by doing it. You're going to make those mistakes in the field. I would say the one key thing that helped me tremendously was having a really great mentor. And I was lucky enough to be working with a veteran filmmaker, Stanley Nelson. And he really has been my mentor throughout this process. I worked with his company, Firelight Media, for a good six or seven years, and it was through working with that company that I got to try on different roles in production to sort of get that broad-based experience. But he was the one that was sort of always saying try this, giving me advice whether I wanted it or not. So I would suggest to anyone that's interested in this is to look up someone whose work you really admire, and try to cultivate a relationship with

MR: Good advice. I was curious about if your film — is Mary Lou Williams your first solo effort?

CB: Um hum. Yes.

MR: Okay. So is there a script first of all, for the film?

CB: Yes. Yes.

MR: Is the script driven by the available resources that you can find?

CB: Um hum. Yes. You know one thing that I'm trying to do with the film is to tell her story through her words. And so what we did, we, my team and I, in researching her was to basically extract all the written words through her unpublished autobiographies, oral words through radio interviews, she did an oral history, video interviews. So it was basically just extrapolating everything that she had said, whether in print or media, and creating a script based on that. So yes, the script are her words telling her story, you know, chronologically basically. And I'd say the challenge in that is that Mary Lou — well the good thing is that we did take various different kinds of source materials. Because what she said later on in life on video was kind of very scripted for her. She knew exactly what her history was and she wasn't straying from that. But she was very much more open maybe in the 1950's, talking to a reporter. So we would use that. It was really hunting down real nuggets.

MR: Is that what some of your interns do and your researchers, or do you mostly do that yourself?

CB: I usually do that myself. And I have to be honest, my editor and I, my editor is actually a co-writer on this. We both were going through, while she should be editing, instead, you know, we're going through articles, and oh look what she said here, oh look at this quote, this is a good one. And so the both of us really kind of built her story and tried to build the drama of her story through the script.

MR: And what about the m word — the money word? Is that like — I can sort of envision trying to make a budget, and in the back of your mind you're going there's always going to be these hidden things that I'm not going to know about until they get there, and then they won't be accounted for.

CB: Well the m word. The m word is, I try to make as realistic a budget as I can, and, you know, how it's worked with this film basically is that you never get all of what you need at one time. It's always a matter of, you get a grant for X amount of dollars, and that will take you but so far, and you use up that money, and then you just keep applying for grants and basically you're always fundraising to finish the project. It just so happens most recently I got a very large grant that allowed me for several months to really work on this full time and not fundraise. But I'm coming to end of that money too and I still

budgets that you give to foundations, it's a catch-22. If you really told them how much you really need they probably wouldn't fund you. So you always have to sort of be conservative with the figures you give out, to make it seem like it is something that they would be interested in funding. It's a game.

MR: So you definitely don't want to pad your budget because you have a feeling that I'm not thinking about something that I'm going to have to fund, but if you make it too big then they won't look at it.

CB: Right. Right. I mean you have to pad your budget a little bit. But yes, you're never being really realistic with how much you really need. Because it's expensive. And a funder will look at it and they won't understand, they're not filmmakers, and how come this budget is too — it's so expensive? Do you really need this much money? So they'll just go to the next documentary or the next project that they think can be funded with less money.

MR: Here's a question you probably couldn't answer, but if you had a very wealthy backer who said "you know what? I'm just going to keep funding this as long as you want." Might you never finish the film?

CB: Oh God that would be heaven.

MR: I mean there's something about running out of money that makes you say well I've got to finish this.

CB: Right, exactly. There is an end game to this if you run out of money. Definitely. If I had a wealthy backer — and if you know anybody, please — but no, because no, at the end I want this film to get finished. I want the film to be completed. I want Mary Lou's legacy to get out there, I want this film to go on to its next journey and get out there in the world. I mean I don't want to be a perpetual first time filmmaker. I want to move on.

MR: And how does it get out there in the world? You mentioned that PBS is a potential market for the film, and then there's overseas. How do you make all that happen?

CB: Well with the chunk of money I got, I basically got quote unquote completion funding for the project. And that was through PBS. And part of getting that money was the understanding was that when it's finished it will be broadcast on public television. So once it gets to a certain point, probably the next phase, the fine cut, this entity, my funder, will take the project and pitch it to the different PBS series and they will decide where it's going to end up on PBS. So my contact is specifically for this program being broadcast on PBS. But as far as international, what happens is that I will also look for an agent maybe, a sales agent or a distributor that would be interested in approaching foreign broadcasters for that kind of broadcast abroad. You know I'm also interested in it going out to the film festival circuit and I'm just applying. But more importantly what I really wanted to do is for it to live in the educational setting, whether through libraries or

sort of a tool for community outreach and inspiring young people and bringing awareness to jazz education. So that's really the mission of the film is to sort of keep it moving forward in the community.

MR: Remind me after we're done to tell you about the Jazz Education Network annual gathering that might be a possibility. Actually, fairly recently I also had an interview with another documentary filmmaker, Burrill Crohn.

CB: Oh yes.

MR: And Burrill said a couple of things that I wanted to ask you about. He said when he was first getting into it and he finally got a camera in his hands how exciting that was, but the real camera person said "shooting is one thing, but it's really the lighting, that's the art." I see you nodding your head.

CB: Um hum. Yes. Absolutely. Yeah. The art of photography is the lighting. It's how you sculpt what's in front of the camera through manipulating the lighting. You know so it's an art and it's a craft. I am a camera person too. I can hold a camera and compose a decent shot but I am not a director of photography. You know I hire those people who have that eye and that sensibility and really understanding of the different light sources and how to manipulate the light to create a beautiful image in front of the camera. Yes. He's right.

MR: It makes me wonder about my light in here now. He also said you can rescue bad video but you can't rescue bad sound.

CB: He is so right. Well of course, he's a veteran. He knows, this is absolutely right. People will forgive a bad image, if it's out of focus or it's not quite composed right. That's okay if they can hear the content. But you can't, if it's really unsettling to the ear you're not going to focus in, you're probably going to be a little bit repelled by that. Because it's very sensitive. Your hearing is very sensitive, and so it's critical that when you're shooting something that the sound is really the best quality it can be.

MR: It makes me think about the times I've done some recording and if there's a moment in the recording when you feel like you need to explain something to the listener, you know that that's not good. Like yeah I know the bass player made a mistake there. And if you have to explain it —

CB: Right. Right. Right. And it's so funny because a lot of filmmakers, it's always about the visual and the picture, and the sound is really like the stepchild. But it really is, the sound is so much more important in the end for the listener, than the visual.

MR: Now do you own your own gear?

CB: Um hum.

MR: To some extent?

CB: Um hum. I have a basic camera. I have a SONY pd 150, you know it's out of date now, it's a mini-dv camera. And I have a very basic lighting kit. Because I mean I can shoot, I can compose a shot, and quite honestly, in those situations, in this documentary there were times when I didn't have the money and yet I wanted to interview somebody, whether they were moving on in years or they were in a location that I could get to. So I shot, you know, with my pd 150 and my basic lighting kit and, you know, it works. But believe me, when I have the money to pay for a professional, I pay for a professional, absolutely.

MR: Some things have gotten cheaper, I mean less expensive. Like you probably do, do you have an editing machine or a suite or something, instead of paying a company three or four hundred dollars an hour?

CB: Well you know that's the other thing. I mean yes, I have Final Cut Pro on my laptop, you know, but I'm not an editor. Again, editing is a craft. I have an editor who's fantastic. And what she does, and how she paces out the visual and the audio and creates a mood through the materials is something that I couldn't do. It's really a craft. She went through the channels of apprenticeship and sitting at the heels of well-known editors, I mean she has been doing this for decades. So I'm not going to presume that I could come in there, even if I have the software, that I'd be able to edit like that.

MR: That is a danger. Too many people have the toys now and they think that, yeah, I can make a record now because I have the —

CB: And there's nothing wrong with doing it yourself. But I think you have to be humble in that process. You know I do think you can't do it all yourself. I think a film suffers if you're doing everything. You really do need outside eyes to sort of help you with the materials. Because you can't see objectively. And yeah, but sometimes, it calls for, as I said, the financing's not there and you've got to go out there and shoot or you don't have the money and you can edit, you know, you've got to do what you've got to do. But I totally agree that the best way is to just get somebody who really has that real fine sense of craft to help you with your film.

MR: Let's talk about Mary Lou a little more. One thing I noticed about her words, and the words you used in the film, is that she didn't blame the downsides of her career on social issues very much. She didn't complain "if I had been a white woman" or "if I had been a man." I didn't hear that a lot. And I thought that was very interesting.

CB: Yeah. She never — she never felt, from what I've read, that being a woman held her back. Whether I agree with that is one thing. But she once said, she once compared herself, she always thought of herself as being just as fine a musician as one of the guys. She knew her art. And so she never allowed that to stand in her way. So she was not one

or "I could have gone beyond this boundary." She didn't really see herself that way. She just kept forging forward. Now that doesn't mean that that's the case. I kind of do feel that had she been a man it would have been a different situation for her on some levels. But she didn't see it that way I don't think.

MR: She very well could have, if she was a he, gone out and had her own band. I mean that would have been a standard thing in the industry. Somebody becomes a star within the band and then the next logical step, to have my own big band or whatever.

CB: Um hum. And I also feel that just from reading the critics and how her music was looked at, she was always the kitten on the keys, and girl piano player.

MR: Or as, I think it was her husband, said "she played just like a man."

CB: Right. Right. Right. And actually she herself said that too.

MR: Really.

CB: So I mean indirectly you're acknowledging that it's a man's world out there and you're a woman in it. And you're going to be seen, no matter how big your craft and your artistry, you're being seen on that standard. So I mean yes, you are fighting that battle, whether you knowledge it or choose to go around it, you're still dealing with it.

MR: You mentioned Ken Burns, or someone asked you about Ken Burns I guess, did you have an opinion about his big long history that he did of jazz?

CB: Well of course I saw, well for one thing my editor edited two of his —

MR: What's her name?

CB: Sandra Christie.

MR: Okay.

CB: She edited two of the programs in his series. I actually enjoyed the series. I mean clearly there are some figures left out, but you can't do it all. And I'm glad actually he left out Mary Lou to an extent. He mentioned her, so that means that somebody else has to take up that torch. I think there was a lot of focus on, it would have been interesting had maybe he gone a little bit more into the contemporary jazz movement. I mean it was very much more focused on the thirties and the forties and the fifties. You know it would have been interesting. But I think all-in-all I did enjoy the series. I think he did a fine job.

MR: Yeah. Overall it's a very useful tool.

CB: Great writing. Great writing.

MR: Have you met him? You know I was going to say, is it an oxymoron to say that there's such a thing as a well-to-do documentary filmmaker? Maybe he's the one.

CB: You know look, between Ken Burns and Michael Moore, God bless them.

MR: Right.

CB: I am just not mad at him for being successful. I mean he has it. He has that funding, he has that backing, he has PBS that is loving everything that he comes out with, and he's able to do these long format historical documentaries. Good for him.

MR: Right.

CB: Good for him.

MR: Yeah I used to feel sometimes that the people that complain about it have maybe a bit of professional jealousy there.

CB: Oh of course it is. Of course it is.

MR: It's the same with musicians too.

CB: I have met Ken Burns, and I have met his brother, Rick Burns. They're brilliant. They're brilliant, and very nice in person. They're really very nice men. He wouldn't remember me, but, you know.

MR: Is there anything that your time at Hamilton led you down this path?

CB: When I was at Hamilton I think I was much more focused on writing. So it was a reaffirmation for me that no matter what I was going to do it was going to be something creative. I think what Hamilton, what I learned at Hamilton was storytelling. That, even though I was an English major and I was focusing much more on writing, it was what makes a story, and really learning, you know, obviously through reading the literature and dissecting and constructing and deconstructing the writings of great masters, you know it helped me to develop a sort of critical analysis of what people are gravitated to when they sit down to read a book or what I as a writer have to sort of bring out to the audience so that they are compelled to read what I write. And that helped me as far as making people, in crafting a story even on film, you know, that it's the audience that counts and what is it about the story that's going to move people.

MR: Well said.

CB: Thank you.

MR: Yeah. I was lucky enough to have my daughter go here too, and I think it's a great place to go and people turn out pretty well.

CB: They do. And the English department, when I was here, there were some very excellent professors and I just assume the professors are the same as far as being very serious about their work. You know, dedicated and really imparting that to the students.

MR: And your father went here.

CB: He did.

MR: He was one of the few black students at the time, would you say the early fifties?

CB: Class of 1951, yeah, James Bash.

MR: And where we're sitting didn't even exist of course.

MR: It was probably a forest.

CB: Right, exactly. It was all just the old side of the campus. Hamilton was all men. You know, I couldn't imagine what that would be like. This is pre-civil rights movement. You know, so honestly he's proud of Hamilton. He's very proud of being a Hamilton alum but he doesn't really talk much about his college years. And I don't know if it's uncomfortable or if there's some things he kind of wants to keep to himself. Maybe it was hard, I can imagine it was difficult.

MR: Yeah, my impression of reading about those times is that Hamilton was not necessarily on the forefront of change.

CB: Unh unh.

MR: So I could understand that.

CB: So I don't really know much about his college years. He keeps that to himself. And I feel like I don't want to push him.

MR: Now you said you're sort of in your ninth year of this Mary Lou Williams film, so obviously you work on other things at the same time.

CB: Um hum.

MR: In fact I quoted you. You have a whole folder full of ideas.

CB: Oh those are from my upcoming documentaries, right. Right now I am just focused on Mary Lou, because I have the completion funding. So that's actually another one of the stipulations of this, that I only work on this one project a hundred percent. So that's great. But yes, I definitely am looking towards the future. Mary Lou will get out there in the world and I do have some ideas for my next documentary. But I don't, it looks like I'm drawn to yet another figure, another woman, not that that's going to be my career as far as, but I do have someone in mind. But I haven't approached the estate yet or anything so I don't feel like I can really talk about it.

MR: In fact I had that word written down on my little sheets here, the estate word.

CB: Yes.

MR: Is that difficult sometimes?

CB: I think, well luckily for this project no. You know I approached Mary Lou Williams' executor. And he was very open and has been very supportive. But it can be, it can be. You just don't know, until you meet these people or a person or whoever, you just don't know who you're dealing with and what they're expecting or what they want to present as far as that person's legacy and how that might counter what you want to do as a filmmaker. So there's a discussion that needs to take place, and until you have that I've kind of keep it under wraps.

MR: I wonder if it was sort of to your advantage that she didn't have children? Because sometimes I think the kids and the grandkids think that there's lots of money to be made from granddaddy's past.

CB: Yeah, oh wow, the documentary's going to make millions of dollars. Yeah, family can complicate matters. I mean she does have family. She does have sisters and half-sisters who are still alive, and nieces and nephews. But she was very clear that her money goes to her foundation and Father Peter O'Brien, who is the head of her foundation. So it was dealing with him. You know, again, it's a discussion. It depends on what people's mindsets are. And sometimes yes, if the children are involved, what was the relationship with their parents or that person. You know it can get kind of complicated.

MR: What about the — was all the music in the film Mary Lou's music?

CB: Um hum.

MR: Or, well some of it was stuff that she had arranged perhaps.

CB: Yes, exactly. What I intend to do is, the music in the film is either going to be music that she composed, performed or arranged. So one of those three things. She touched it on one of those levels. Yeah, that's the intent. That all the music you hear is somehow credited to her on some level.

MR: And do you have assistance with that? In fact I think we had talked about your music clearance person that you had worked with. That's a whole other ballgame too.

CB: That's a whole other ballgame. You're getting right into the gut here, Monk, with your questions. Yeah music clearance is just a whole other ball of wax. Because it's tracking down the copyright owners and the publishers of all these music compositions and that is so difficult a task at times, that you almost need to have somebody on board that really knows this stuff. So it just behooves me to hire a music supervisor, someone who really understands the music legalities and contracting and negotiating and all that. There's no way I would ever want to do that or have my associate or my co-producer do that. It's just too time-consuming and you just need someone that really has that expertise.

MR: And are you able to — at what point do you put that in your funding applications? How do you — you know what I mean — because you don't necessarily know what music you're going to use from the get-go.

CB: Um hum. Well what I would do is initially, I mean I always had a music supervisor in mind, someone who has a really good history of working with other filmmakers who I admire. And actually, excuse me, this woman, Rina Kosersky, my music supervisor, was a huge fan of Mary Lou Williams, although she ended up not being my music supervisor. She's now working with a foundation. What I did was make a phone call to her and say "how much money should I put in the budget for music?" So basically it might not be the

most accurate figure but it's based on her knowledge and her expertise and so that figure goes into the budget.

MR: It's rocket science.

CB: No it's not. No, no. Don't say that about those rocket scientists. They really are rocket scientists. I am not.

MR: But someone told me, one of your interns, said that your husband is an inventor?

CB: Uh huh. He is.

MR: Wow, you guys have chosen some interesting careers.

CB: I know. Why? Yeah. He's an entrepreneur. He — Myron Alexander is my husband and also a Hamilton alum, same class as mine, '85 — and he basically is a medical device developer/inventor. He invents medical devices. So that's what he does. And he's trying to get his product out on the market as well, this year. So he also was a teacher and he worked with youths and human services, so I mean that was his day job. But now he really is devoting all his time to his development of new products. So yeah, another creative entrepreneur, uncharted path person.

MR: Never a dull moment.

CB: Never a dull moment and never enough money.

MR: Well here's a purely opinion question on my part. It's April 2012 and I'm wondering what's your feeling about our country at the moment.

CB: Wow. I'm kind of disheartened by what I hear as far as the politics are concerned, you know, just the level of animosity between what's going on in our government, you know the republicans and the democrats and not being able to really come together and I think legislate for the populace, for the people. And of course I'm thrilled that there's a black man in the White House, President Obama. I definitely have supported a lot of the initiatives that he's put on the table. But I also am understanding that there is a minefield that he kind of had to sort of go around in trying to reach across the aisle to work with republicans. So you know I do believe he will become the president, he will maintain the presidency during the election. I don't see a republican having that path to the presidency at this point. So on that level I feel optimistic. I feel optimistic. Yeah.

MR: I think you're right. It seems like the republicans in too much of the country have this added impetus to gain back the office, not just because they don't like his policies, but because of what he is. It seems very troubling that three years ago we thought that there would be this bringing together, and instead it feels like it's gone the other way.

CB: It's pulling apart. It's a pulling apart. But I feel on a certain level, you know, those tactics have backfired. Because it's so confrontational and oppositional that I think it's just turning people off. And the democrats clearly have, I mean I think democratic people are

definitely supporting the president, so there's no question there. Yeah, so I mean I think eventually he will become the president for a second term and things will get better.

MR: I like getting political predictions on film. I did it once with Jon Hendricks.

CB: Oh what'd he say?

MR: And he said — well this was way back, God this was twelve years ago. He said "the republicans are dead in the water and they just don't know it." It turned out he was sort of right but not as soon as he wanted to be. There was a few extra years.

CB: Well I think they really are definitely drumming their demise. They're so right on the extreme that I don't see —

MR: You should keep that in mind — what you just said — "drumming their demise." And you can use that somewhere. That's a really good little phrase. I like that.

CB: Okay. Well I think they are.

MR: Well it's been such a pleasure to have you here and I know that we got some nice response. I have a feeling that you'll be back, and not just to visit but to present —

CB: The final project. The real film. I would love to. I would love to. Thank you, Monk. That's a great name.

MR: Best of luck, and thank you for what you're doing. We need you and creative people out there taking on these kind of projects.

CB: Thanks, Monk.

MR: Alright. Best wishes.